REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 05



Product / Project Translator

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Answer the real coordination need without pretending the uncertainty is gone.

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For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

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What do they need that answer for?

You're running Product. Your stakeholder asks for final requirements, a fixed date, or a complete plan while important facts are still being learned.

Begin with their decision

They may need to reserve funding, coordinate a customer message, or sequence another team. Ask what the requested certainty would let them do. Their need deserves a usable answer.

Locate the actual uncertainty

Some delivery work is well understood and can be planned. Other work needs discovery. Don't label every request project thinking; show which assumption needs evidence in this particular situation.

Your win as the PM

Give the stakeholder something dependable now: a bounded commitment, a useful checkpoint, and a decision they can make. Keep your relationship intact while making uncertainty workable.

How this kit helps

The Guide teaches the translation. The Lab walks one real request into a Request Decoder, a Commitment Card, and a Stakeholder Response you can take into the meeting.

> Lead with the answer that helps them coordinate. Explain the product method only when it helps that decision.

Get clear before you go back into the room.

A certainty request can sound like someone misunderstanding your job. Before correcting them, ask what they are trying to protect.

Separate the event from your interpretation

Write the actual request, words, or decision. Then name the story you're adding about the person. You can feel frustrated and still ask a useful question about their constraints.

Name your Why

What outcome could you and this stakeholder create together? Reliable budgeting, a customer message people can trust, or a delivery sequence that can adapt without surprises?

Paint a future they can help shape

Describe what better would look like in daily work: customers can plan, the team can focus, or decisions happen before commitments change. Invite the other person to improve the picture. A shared ambition needs their authorship too.

Keep private preparation private

The Lab saves these notes in your browser and excludes them from shared outputs. Export the working brief you want others to see; don't send your untested motive story.

> Try: I want us to make this work. Can we look together at the outcome, the constraints, and the decision we need?

Treat your interpretation as a question.

You can't know the stakeholder's motive from the sentence alone. Confirm the coordination need before designing your response.

Final requirements

Ask which decision needs the requirements and which details must be stable. Funding may need an outcome, spending boundary, and staged decision rather than every interaction settled in advance.

A committed date

Ask what is tied to it: contract, customer communication, staffing, or another team's work. You may need a delivery forecast and tradeoff, not simply a lecture about uncertainty.

A complete roadmap

Ask the planning horizon and decisions it supports. Explain which near-term work is committed, which later work is directional, and when evidence could change the sequence.

Record what they actually said

The Lab separates your assumed need from the confirmation. If you haven't asked yet, the decoder stays a hypothesis to check with the stakeholder.

> Try: What decision will this answer help you make, and by when? Which part needs to be dependable for that decision?

Replace vague uncertainty with a bounded offer.

What can you responsibly provide now? Make it specific enough for someone else to plan around.

Known and supported

State the customer outcome, constraints, and evidence already available. If you have a reliable delivery forecast for a known slice of work, use it with its conditions.

Unknown and consequential

Name the uncertainty that changes the plan: customer behavior, technical feasibility, approval, or dependency. Say how it will be tested or resolved, by whom, and when.

A commitment you can own

Commit to an agreed discovery scope, evidence review, assessment, or delivery slice with the relevant owners. Don't promise a result beyond your control merely because a date is requested.

A boundary people can use

Define budget, scope, quality, approvals, and a stopping or revision condition. A discovery checkpoint should lead to a decision rather than becoming indefinite permission to explore.

> Commitment Card: what we will do, under which conditions, with which owner, and what decision the evidence will support.

Give the room a short, useful response.

The first paragraph should help the stakeholder act. Put the detail in the Commitment Card.

Recognize their need

I understand you need a funding decision for next quarter. Use the need they have actually confirmed rather than a motive you've assigned.

State the dependable offer

We can define the outcome and a capped discovery investment now. The team will test two workflow options within that boundary before we ask for the full build budget.

Name the next evidence and decision

At the two-week review, we'll bring customer findings and a delivery assessment. You can then approve, revise, or stop the next investment.

Ask for the decision you need

Can you approve the discovery boundary and name the budget decision owner by Thursday? This turns the response into a working agreement people can accept or change.

> Response pattern: I understand you need X. We can offer Y now. Z remains open. We'll bring evidence by this date so you can decide A.

Adapt the answer to the real need.

These are conversation starters, not scripts for dismissing a reasonable request.

Just give me the date

Offer the team-supported forecast for a defined scope if one exists. If it doesn't, state the assessment and checkpoint needed. If a hard date is real, use Deadline Reset to shape the scope tradeoff.

We can't approve an open-ended budget

Propose a capped phase, an owner, evidence criteria, and a funding gate. Say what that phase will and will not establish. The budget owner can decline or revise it.

We need to tell the customer something

Give approved wording about the current outcome, delivery status, and next update. Coordinate with the person who owns the external message. Don't substitute your preferred wording for a contractual commitment.

Why does the roadmap keep changing?

Show which evidence changed, the outcome that stays stable, and the choice now being made. Separate learning from avoidable churn, and acknowledge communication or planning failures where they happened.

> Useful translation meets their coordination need and leaves the remaining uncertainty visible.

Finance needs a decision, not every requirement.

Fictional case: a finance sponsor requests final requirements before reserving next-quarter funding for a new customer workflow.

The Request Decoder

PM asks what the requirements will support. Finance confirms the funding need. The final workflow is not yet tested; the customer outcome and initial investment boundary can be defined.

The Commitment Card

Propose testing two candidate workflows within a capped two-week discovery phase. PM owns the customer study; Engineering owns the delivery assessment. No production release is promised by that checkpoint.

The Stakeholder Response

I can give you the outcome, investment boundary, and next funding decision now. At the two-week review, we'll bring customer evidence and a delivery assessment before asking you to commit to the full build.

The decision and follow-through

In this fictional case, Finance approves the capped phase Thursday. PM records the agreement and schedules the two-week evidence review. Full-build funding remains open; a negative result can justify revising or stopping. The Lab example starts with the proposal so you can rehearse the funding conversation.

> Finance can reserve a bounded investment. Product has a learning commitment and a clear next funding decision.

Translate one live request into a usable answer.

Open your Product / Project Translator Lab. Nic's walkthrough works through the same process on a realistic example.

The Request

Capture the actual sentence, stakeholder, and context. Starter prompts can help you rehearse. Private reflection stays out of every shared output.

Decode

Choose the coordination need, record what the stakeholder confirmed, and identify the assumption to check. Export the Request Decoder to prepare the conversation.

Commitment

Write the outcome, known evidence, unknowns, bounded commitment, and next checkpoint. Export the Commitment Card as the detail behind your answer.

Respond

Draft the short message, decision request, owner, and date. Keep status as a proposal until agreement. Record the response and next action, then copy, download, or print the Stakeholder Response.

> Load the fictional example to rehearse. It is clearly labeled and does not pretend a real stakeholder has agreed.

Use the next conversation to learn.

A useful brief changes what happens next. Give it an owner, take it into your existing work tools, and return to the evidence.

Follow through on one move

Check whether the response helped the stakeholder make their actual decision. Bring the promised evidence on the agreed date. If the need was misunderstood or the commitment was too vague, revise the offer and confirm it again.

Rehearse with a trusted peer

Read your opening aloud. Ask: Is the observation fair? Is the recommendation specific? Could the other person disagree without being cast as the villain? Revise the wording before the real conversation.

Keep a record you can return to

Lab drafts stay in this browser on this device. Copy, download, or print your outputs. Export before clearing browser data or moving devices. The tool does not send messages, update your roadmap, or create authority.

Judge the change by what happens

What did the other person hear? Was a decision made? Did anyone act? Review the next real result rather than treating completion of the Lab as proof that the organizational problem is solved.

> You arrive with a situation. You leave with a proposal, a decision record, or a specific question that somebody can act on.